Week 19: Apocalyptic Literature

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

"Apocalyptic" is one of the most misunderstood words in the Bible — tonight we'll look at what it actually means.

1. When you hear the word "apocalyptic" or "the apocalypse," what images come to mind? Does that picture come more from the Bible, or from movies and pop culture?

2. **Read 2 Kings 6:8-17.** Elisha's servant panics at the army surrounding the city. Elisha prays, "LORD, please open his eyes." What does the servant see once his eyes are opened — and what has actually changed in the situation? This tiny scene is "apocalyptic" in the truest sense of the word. Based on it, how would you define an "apocalypse"?

3. **Read Ezekiel 1:1-4, then 1:26-2:2.** Ezekiel is a war refugee beside a canal in Babylon when the sky opens. What does he see, and what does it do to his body? Why might a vision of God enthroned — *mobile*, out beyond the ruined temple — matter so much to someone who has just watched his homeland destroyed?

4. **Read Zechariah 4.** The prophet sees a golden lampstand and two olive trees and asks the interpreting angel, "What are these, my lord?" The heart of the answer is verse 6: "Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit." How does wrapping that line inside strange imagery deliver it with more force than just saying it plainly?

5. The same stock of images — the raging sea, monstrous beasts, a throne above the waters — turns up again and again across the Bible, starting in Genesis 1. Why do you think the biblical writers kept reusing the same pictures instead of inventing new ones? How would "studying the rest of your Bible" actually help you read a book like Revelation?

6. **Read Revelation 5.** John weeps because no one can open the scroll. He's told, "The Lion of the tribe of Judah has conquered" — and turns to see "a Lamb standing, as though it had been slain." What is the vision doing by swapping a lion for a slaughtered lamb at the exact moment of triumph?

7. Because "apocalypse" means "unveiling" rather than "catastrophe," how might that change the way you'd want to read — or hear sermons about — the book of Revelation?

8. Every one of these visions was given to someone facing something hard — exile, a besieging army, a church under pressure — to let them see their situation from above. What's a hard "present moment" in your life where you could use that same kind of perspective?

9. What's one piece of hope from these passages that you want to carry with you into this week?

10. This is the last week of our 19-week study. Looking back across everything we've covered — from what the Bible even is, to how to read each of its different genres, all the way to this apocalyptic imagery — what's one way your approach to reading Scripture has actually changed?